Review a QR-code request

Try the cases first. These discussion answers do not establish that a real agency has these procedures or that a technical control works.

Q1 An unexpected document

The sender, document and destination are not confirmed. A familiar name and the message's phone number do not independently confirm the request.

Do not scan just to find out. Ask the carrier through a number or portal already known to the agency, independently of the message. If it cannot be confirmed, use the agency's suspicious-message reporting process. The note alone does not establish fraud.

Q2 A setup you started

The staff member initiated an agency-approved setup through the approved portal and recognizes the instructions. Follow the agency's process; if a later screen or request is unexpected, pause and ask the administrator through a trusted route. A QR code alone does not prove a request is safe or fraudulent.

Q3 A scan already happened

The coworker reports scanning an unexpected code with a personal phone. Whether a page opened, credentials were entered, a sign-in was approved, a download occurred or a payment was submitted remains unknown. Do not assume compromise or that nothing happened.

Promptly contact the agency's IT provider or security lead through a trusted route. Report the device, approximate time, scan and each known or uncertain action. Preserve the message as instructed by the incident procedure. Do not send passwords, one-time codes, customer records or the suspicious link to an unverified contact. If money was sent, promptly contact the payment provider through a verified number and follow the agency's incident process.

The cases are fictional and were prepared with AI assistance. The FBI alert describes QR phishing against other organizations; it does not establish an agency attack.

FBI QR-code phishing alert, 8 January 2026